

QED SHANKAR AIYAR

Politics of Now or Never



Politics, said Otto Von Bismarck, is the art of the possible. Much later, John Kenneth Galbraith said politics is not the art of the possible. It consists in choosing between the disastrous and the unpalatable. As India awaits the outcome of the egotistical battle between the Congress and the Left over the nuclear deal, Indian voters and politicians must wonder if the possible has to be either disastrous or unpalatable.

Definitions of what is disastrous or unpalatable could differ depending on where one stands on the nuke issue and the political hue card but it can't be denied that the voters deserve better. It isn't being broadcast as yet but they could justifiably ask why couldn't UPA and the Left manage this better? Did the Congress and the allies who applauded the deal believe that the Left would join the chorus? Did the Left not know in 2005 that the deal would change the contours of India's foreign policy? Perhaps both believed in their own optimism but their belief has brought political instability at a time when global uncertainties are already threatening growth.

SAURABH SINGH



It may not be obvious to Congressmen but UPA regime couldn't have had it any better. Three years of stupendous growth, BJP—and you don't have to say more—for Opposition and no lethal scandal or calamity. With favourable results expected in the assembly polls there was neither cause for concern nor any threat anywhere on the horizon to the alliance completing its term. Indeed, thanks to a bumper crop of taxes, the next two budgets afforded the Congress—with some helpful suggestions from the Left—a shot at being St. Profligate to cast a wider net for votes. All of the above are sufficient conditions for the Left to stay with UPA.

The moot Q then is why would the Congress sacrifice nearly two years of power for the N-deal? The issue is not about the merit of the deal but the political worth of the deal—the two are and must be viewed separately. The problem with the votaries of the deal is that they tend to confuse merit—which is the subject of much debate—with the political cost. Why should it be now or never? Is a deal in the bush worth more than the power in hand? Is it worth jeopardising growth? Can the deal go through if the Left pulls out? The way out is to put the deal on hold till after the polls in 2009. If they do get a full house, they could work with a new saddle-mate in Washington and make the deal truly bipartisan. It is up to the Congress to choose between the disastrous and the possible.

SAIBAL DAS



UNNERVED:
Badal

Battle for Populism

CHANDIGARH The ruling Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and BJP coalition in Punjab are at loggerheads over fresh hike in power tariff for urban consumers. BJP is against it as the party does not want its votebank to be burdened with the cost of providing free power to farmers who form the SAD support base. Balbir Punj, BJP general secretary in charge of the state, has threatened that his party will boycott the forthcoming meeting of the state Cabinet. Though Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal has showed

little signs of succumbing, tough talk by Punj unnerved him into seeking the intervention of BJP top brass L.K. Advani and Rajnath Singh. Badal's damage control efforts are understandable because the BJP prop is the key to the coalition in power. With the possibility of a mid-term Lok Sabha poll gaining currency, both SAD and BJP are in an overdrive to placate their respective votebanks; a corollary of the politics of populism that has already put the coalition under a strain.

by Ramesh Vinayak

HK RAJASHEKAR



Chief Writer

CHENNAI Cinema has long been a tool of artistic pursuit and political growth for Dravidian politicians. A short story, *Saarappallam Chamundi*, penned 43 years ago by Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi for the

special Pongal issue of DMK journal *Murasoli* in 1964, is set to be made into a film now. Named *Uliyin Oasai* (sound of the chisel) and directed by P. Kannan, it will be released in January next on Pongal.

Karunanidhi started his career as a story and screenplay writer for Tamil film *Parashakti* (pure consciousness), which was released in 1952. He scripted *Kannamma* in 2005 as he had ample time to spare when he was out of power.

by S. Senthil Kumar